



always the next best move for your business. You may end up losing more money and, in worst case, closing down your business if you implement this technology recklessly. This is apart from the investment made in the technology. Here we list down three ways big data analytics can go wrong.

COLLECTING THE WRONG INFORMATION

Let's elaborate with an example. If we recall, the later half of the last decade was marred by flu and thus, seeing the perfect business opportunity, Google launched Google Flu Trends—a program that provides real-time monitoring of flu cases around the world, based on Google searches that match terms with flu-related activity.

Case Study: Google Flu Trends

Launched in 2008, Google Flu Trends (GFT) used big data analytics to gather data through search queries to predict flu outbreaks in around 25 countries. Algorithms were used to mine data (keywords like cold and fever were used to collect data), which was then

compared with the frequency of flu outbreaks in a particular region to get the desired results.

Result. It could not predict H1N1 virus and in 2013, when the world recorded the highest number of flu cases, GFT grossly failed to predict the same, giving a result wrong by 140 per cent. The grossly incorrect results led to the search engine giant shutting down the GFT and losing out a huge amount of money.

What they did wrong. While Google did use big data analytics, it failed to understand that this technology can be fruitful only when right algorithms are in place, which was not the case with GFT.

The results were based on search queries with common words like cold and fever, which eventually gave disastrous results.

BEING LAZY WITH BIG DATA RESULTS

Believing big data blindly can be dangerous for your business.

Case Study: Target Retail

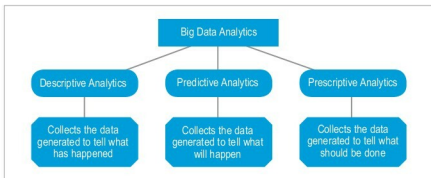
Target Retail used big data analytics to understand its customers' buying behaviour, shopping trends and personal information such as anniversaries, marital status and birthdays for target marketing.

Result. The father of a teenage girl stormed into a Target store to question the staff about sending pre- and post-natal offers to his daughter. Though he later found out that his teenage daughter was indeed pregnant, Target suffered a serious blow to its brand reputation as customers realised that their sensitive data was not kept private and instead shared with the marketing team.

What they did wrong. Those using the data did not bother to check the age bracket or verify whether the target customers were the right set. They ended up embarrassing their customers by disclosing sensitive data, thus paying a huge price for their error.

USING WRONG ALGORITHMS

Big data analytics can prove fatal for your business if the algorithms entered are incorrect. This is ex-



Simplifying the big data analytics jargon